The King's Gambit: A Domestic Explanation of Democratic Transition in Japan

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Abstract

Why do dominant parties voluntarily democratize? Dominant view democratization as a result of revolutionary pressure (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006). Recent scholarship that focuses democratization beyond the European or American contexts discovered that democratization can happen with elite confidence in electoral victory in Asia (Slater and Wong 2022). While Asian democratizations have been perceived as operating under the shadow of U.S. security umbrella and ideological influence, I present a domestic mechanism to explain democratization "by confidence" (Slater and Wong 2022). Using classic social learning where citizens update beliefs about ruler quality by observing sequential endorsements, I identify three equilibrium regimes, low-trust turnover, mid-trust intervention that prevents protest bandwagon, and high-trust entrenchment, each sustained by the interaction between civic confidence and rulers' incentives to manage information flows. I show that a ruling party whose reputation falls in the intermediate range can profitably "democratize" by subsidizing a credible opposition: the cost of competitive elections screens the candidate pool, raises the opposition's reputation above the entrenchment threshold, and thereby locks in one-party dominance under the guise of electoral competition.

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1 Introduction

Democracy seems like a serendipity for the Japanese conservative. Most think it was a reluctant compromise under excessive U.S. pressure during occupation, and yet it miraculously perpetualized a one-party dominance and entrenchment for almost a century with a four-year break in the 1990s. The recently achieved supermajority by Takaichi under the recent snap election granted her the capacity to amend article 9 of the constitution and accelerate other right-leaning policies via procedurally just means. While U.S. influence might explain initiation of democracy, the long history of entrenchment and emboldening of the Japanese conservative does not seem like a success explained away by path dependency. The conservative must have good reasons to keep the regime choice as it is, and few have specified a domestic mechanism for its sustaining.

What is the best way to capture the dynamic in the early modernization of Japan after the war? Most political economy models assume that voters have a fixed and sophisticated commitment to a distribution of policy preferences and match their preferred policies to the platforms provided by politicians when devising their voting strategies. This is also true of how we understand autocratic citizens, who seem to have committed to a set of ideals for good governance and concern themselves only with how popular their original position is when strategizing for collective action. Both of these approaches assume a level of commitment from citizens to their fixed set of preferences, which seems unrealistic. Instead, citizens are often choosing under uncertainty, selecting leaders for their character and capacity (Fearon 1999) rather than matching preferences to platforms.

This element of learning and uncertainty is especially pronounced in the early stages of development in Asia, where citizens are simultaneously acquiring knowledge about political institutions, civic norms, party systems, and standards of good governance, often at the same time as political elites themselves. In such contexts, human capital plays an unusually decisive role in setting developmental trajectories, heightening the significance of selection mechanisms for political leadership. Crucially, politicians do not necessarily learn about how capable they are before coming to office and participating in everyday administrative workflow. Whether to democratize is thus the central theme in many Asian regions and countries seeking to modernize their economies. The answer to this question seems heavily influenced by the geopolitical alliances regions formed with or against the United States. As Slater and Wong (2022) point out, however, the domestic dimension does matter, and democratic transition almost never succeeds without a domestic appeal.

The Japanese case clarifies what this paper is trying to explain. Even in a polity where conservative rule has been remarkably durable, the key political problem is not simply coerc-

ing citizens or inheriting legitimacy from the U.S. occupation, but sustaining *confidence* when information is scarce and elite signals are contested. Takaichi's decision to dissolve the lower house and seek an immediate electoral mandate illustrates the logic: rather than insulating the government from public scrutiny, the ruling party voluntarily widened the audience that evaluates it, converting a potentially destabilizing environment of intra-elite disagreement into an observable, aggregative signal of governing capacity. The snap election on February 8, 2026 delivered the LDP 316 of 465 seats, a two-thirds supermajority, thereby transforming public endorsement into a resource that disciplines factions and reframes bureaucratic and media skepticism. Yet the theoretical claim of this paper is not that elections mechanically reveal "true" quality; it is that dominant parties can strategically use competitive elections to shape learning. When a dominant party's reputation lies in an intermediate range, it can profitably democratize by subsidizing a credible opposition: the cost of campaigning and contestation screens the challenger pool, elevates the opposition's perceived quality above the protest-banding threshold, and redirects civic energy away from destabilizing coordination and toward procedurally contained competition. The result is a paradoxical equilibrium in which democratization is not a concession to revolutionary pressure but an equilibrium instrument of entrenchment, a way to lock in one-party dominance under the guise of electoral accountability.

2 Related literature

The argument I develop builds on three conversations in political economy that have largely proceeded in parallel. By bringing them together, I offer a mechanism that each alone leaves underspecified.

First, the model's core engine is social learning. Banerjee (1992) and Bikhchandani et al. (1992) showed that when rational agents observe the sequential decisions of their predecessors, they may rationally disregard their own private information and follow the crowd. Beyond a certain point, information stops being communicated as all rational agents follow the crowds. In other words, some sequential revelation of public information can result in an information cascade (Bikhchandani et al. 2024) sustained not by strong evidence but by the rational suppression of private signals. It is possible, therefore, that the crowd is locked in a wrong cascade.

The political implication is immediate. If citizens evaluate their leaders sequentially, observing earlier assessments before forming their own, then a few early endorsements can lock an entire population into support for a regime whose quality only few have independently verified. I extend this logic by giving the ruler an institutional toolkit: the capacity

to reassign officials, restructure oversight committees, or call snap elections that reset the information stream. The cascade is no longer a passive phenomenon. It becomes a strategic instrument of governance.

The extent to which this power of transforming the cascade can be wielded hinges on trust endowed in the incumbent. Trust and quality of governance often goes hand in hand, as Hetherington (1998) demonstrated this bidirectional relationship, low trust makes governance harder, which further erodes trust. Aghion et al. (2010) formalized the vicious cycle in the regulatory domain, showing that distrust generates demand for regulation, which breeds corruption, which deepens distrust. At the other extreme, Achen and Bartels (2017) and Bartels (2023) showed that high trust can coexist with poor accountability when citizens lack the information to evaluate rulers. My model captures both pathologies, the low-trust turnover trap and the high-trust entrenchment trap, as opposite ends of the same parameter space.

Recent empirical work confirms the asymmetry at the heart of this framework. Individual-level panel data reveal that trust is remarkably stable over the long run but responsive to government alternation in the short run, with effects that dissipate within a few years (Devine and Valgarðsson 2024). Cross-nationally, trust in representative institutions has declined on average, while trust in implementing institutions—police, civil service—has *increased*, suggesting that the erosion is specific to how politics is practiced rather than a generalized anti-institutional mood (Valgarðsson et al. 2025). Low-trust societies are significantly more likely to experience political turnover during economic crises (Nunn et al. 2018), precisely the mechanism my model attributes to the low-confidence regime. And the distinction between "responsive distrust"—citizens correctly penalizing poor performance—and "unresponsive distrust"—alienation that persists despite improving governance—maps directly onto the model's equilibrium structure.

For East Asian democracies specifically, political institutional factors dominate cultural explanations of trust (Choi and Woo 2016), while a troubling deconsolidation trend sees pluralities of citizens in Japan, South Korea, and Taiwan expressing preference for more autocratic alternatives (Shin 2021). The "Asian paradox" of high trust amid mixed performance may be sustained partly by authoritarian cultural orientations that inflate perceived confidence beyond what governance quality warrants (Baniamin 2025)—a finding that resonates with my entrenchment equilibrium, where civic confidence exceeds the threshold regardless of ruler type. Electoral turnovers, when they do occur, improve economic performance and democratic quality (Marx et al. 2025), but the type of alternation matters: wholesale government change produces greater democratic satisfaction than partial alternation (Otjes 2025), a finding with direct implications for comparing Japan's gradual opening with Taiwan's

decisive 2000 transition.

Both of these contries were featured by a strong autocrat by the time they pursue political liberalization, which leaves an enduring puzzle for people who assumed that relinquishing power must be forced instead of a result of grace. More generally, why do authoritarian regimes liberalize? The classic answers such as elite splits, civil society pressure, bargaining between hard-liners and soft-liners (Huntington 1991; O'Donnell and Schmitter 1986; Przeworski 1991) explain many transitions but leave a puzzle for dominant-party regimes. These are not brittle dictatorships that crack under pressure. They are durable systems in which a single party governs for decades under formally competitive institutions, winning election after election without obvious fraud.

Pempel (1990) documented this phenomenon as "uncommon democracy," with Japan's LDP as the paradigmatic case. Magaloni (2006) argued that Mexico's PRI sustained itself through resource advantages and the strategic manipulation of electoral rules. Greene (2007) extended this analysis, showing that dominant parties exploit state resources to raise the cost of opposition entry, effectively pricing competitors out of the political marketplace. Formal models have treated democratization as elite concessions under revolutionary threat (Acemoglu and Robinson 2006), as asset-mobility-driven bargaining (Boix 2003), or as information extraction where the dictator learns about citizen demands through elections (Miller 2013). But none models the mechanism I identify here: a dominant party that deliberately *creates* a costly electoral environment to raise the opposition's reputation above the entrenchment threshold.

My model formalizes a complementary logic. Rather than merely raising the cost of opposition entry, the incumbent party can strategically set up competitive elections that paradoxically raise the opposition's reputation. The screening effect of costly elections, which only high-quality challengers can afford to compete in, credibly signals to citizens that the political pool is competent, pushing civic confidence above a certain threshold and locking in one-party dominance under the guise of electoral competition. The mechanism reverses Greene's (2007) causal arrow: where Greene shows that dominant parties lose when resource advantages erode, I show that dominant parties can *win* by voluntarily raising the cost of the game.

This perspective connects to a growing literature on authoritarian-led democratization. Riedl et al. (2020) show that when incumbent party strength is high enough to give authoritarian politicians electoral "victory confidence," they pursue democratic experiments that can culminate in stable outcomes. Yan (2022) finds that former dominant-party regimes produce more durable democracies—consistent with my model's prediction that the party retains organizational advantages under the new equilibrium. And Brownlee (2007) demon-

strates that ruling parties capable of containing elite conflict are the most durable, suggesting that party cohesion is a precondition for the strategic gambit I formalize.

This gambit is sometimes framed as the necessary sequence in a developmental trajectory of a country. Johnson (1982) established the concept with Japan's MITI as the paradigmatic case: a strong, autonomous bureaucracy guiding economic growth through strategic industrial policy. This institutional capacity created a "deep bench" of competent politicians, a condition that makes the king's gambit desirable.

Complementing earlier work by Acemoglu and Robinson (2001, 2006), Slater and Wong (2022) argue that democratization in developmental states is driven not by revolutionary pressure but by elite calculations about the sustainability of authoritarian bargains. Their concept of "democracy through strength", where rulers democratize from confidence rather than desperation, motivates my formal model. The statist developmental parts of Asia are their central cases. But they did not take on the task of analytically distinguishing between the roles of international pressure and U.S. influence from those of domestic pressure in shaping the semi-perpetual regime choice. Where Slater and Wong leave the mechanism underspecified, I provide a formal account of how civic confidence and screening costs together determine whether democratization produces genuine turnover or locks in one-party dominance.

The Japan case is well documented. Pempel (1998) characterized the 1990s upheaval as a "regime shift" in which coalitions, institutions, and policy profiles transformed simultaneously. Krauss and Pekkanen (2011) traced the LDP's organizational institutions, factions, personal support networks, the Policy Affairs Research Council, which sustained dominance but eventually created rigidities. Scheiner (2006) showed that clientelism combined with fiscal centralization suppressed opposition credibility, while Catalinac (2024) documented how the LDP leveraged dominance to make voter groups compete for government resources. For Taiwan, Cheng (1989) analyzed how the opposition's growing capabilities enabled the quasi-Leninist regime's liberalization, and Rigger (1999) documented the KMT's declining electoral fortunes as multi-party competition took hold. Recent work on "democratic ceilings" in East Asia (Hur and Yeo 2024) argues that nationalist polarization during initial democratization creates persistent limits on democratic quality. My three-equilibrium model provides a mechanism for this ceiling: the entrenchment regime is stable, self-reinforcing, and resistant to democratic deepening — not because of nationalist sentiment per se, but because the information structure that sustains one-party dominance suppresses the signals that would otherwise force accountability.

3 The heuristic argument

Mapping the substantive context to the main conclusion, I would like to foreshadow first the main mechanism and result of the model. The following section characterizes the main equilibria of the paper and contextualizes them in the substantive context. The next section proceeds to discuss the formal setup and microfoundation of the equilibria.

The formal model developed below generates three self-reinforcing equilibrium regimes, each indexed by the level of civic confidence π that citizens invest in the political apparatus. The ex ante payoff for rulers is increasing across regimes: $U^L < U^M < U^H$ where:

1. **Low-trust turnover regime** ($U^L|\pi < \frac{1}{2}$). Citizens are unfortunately too skeptical that even competent rulers cannot sustain support through the natural flow of information. Governance is trapped in a cycle of turnovers: citizens would benefit from effective government intervention, but any intervention is read as evidence of self-dealing. Even the capable type of Ruler is challenged to overturn public perception and mistrust.

2. **No-protest bandwagon regime** ($U^M|\pi \in [\frac{1}{2}, p)$). Citizens grant enough baseline confidence that rulers can prevent protest cascades by managing the information environment. Both good and bad rulers adopt similar preemptive strategies to block antagonistic signals before they accumulate into a bandwagon, thus producing an equilibrium in which turnover is suppressed. The regime is stable but informationally opaque.

3. **Entrenchment regime** ($U^H|\pi > p$). Civil confidence is high enough that both ruler types can construct an all-support equilibrium. Citizens support the regime regardless of private signals; the first citizen's action becomes uninformative, and one-party dominance is self-sustaining.

A party operating in the mid-trust regime would like to push public trust above a certain threshold to achieve entrenchment. But citizens invest trust for good reasons: only when there is effective screening and a sufficiently high cost of entry into political competition do they believe the pool of politicians is trustworthy. Under one-party entrenchment, however, the reward of office is no longer sensitive to type-specific competition, and screening breaks down.

3.1 Democratic transition: what does it mean?

In this framework, democracy functions as a screening device that effectively boosts public trust and works as an equilibrium selection device that a one-party system will have difficulty delivering. A one-party system rarely publicizes the real cost that a politician must pay for

internal discipline and advancement. By contrast, establishing a credible opposition that can contest elections publicizes this cost and credibly raises the perceived quality of the political pool. Only within a specific range of the incumbent party's existing reputation is it "worth the gamble" to set up a costly election that elevates opposition reputation toward the entrenchment threshold, to "democratize by confidence."

The gambits happened when the incumbents fell short of the apex of their powers and initiated a costly signal in the hope of regaining electoral leverage. More specifically, in the early stages of democratization, the conservatives suffered an initial loss to the socialist expansive coalition but soon reverted to leadership through a snap election. This is echoed in recent events, where Takaichi called upon a general election after the loss of a 26-year old party ally walking on her. The same maneuver was executed by the Kuomingtang in the termination of the martial law, where Chiang surprisingly allowed the opposition party to take power after episodes of quite successfully repressed social movements. The prospect of an opposition takeover back then was so bleak that Chiang believed that the Tangwai group posed no serious threat but stepping stone for a power move (Slater and Wong 2022; Wong 2001).

Besides a profitable precondition of trust, the gambits also needed another strategic component: ruthless commitment. The commitment includes forfeiting popularity when you are capable and in office, as in the Japanese experience, and accepting electoral failure, as in the Taiwanese experience. It has been well documented that the Japanese LDP, despite a long-lasting tenure, suffers meager popularity (Pempel 1998) throughout their half-century political dominance after WWII. The party achieves dominance not because they were always the obvious choice, but because they are consistently good enough to be selected as slightly more capable than others. The model predicts this as a central feature of entrenchment, as the Ruler relinquishes popularity gain in good times to feed into the electoral prospect of the incapable.

In a nutshell, the ability to credibly commit to the consequences of the democratic rules and the ability to devise an insurance policy against times of bad governance create the regime of entrenchment under democratic rule. But I have been silent on the microfoundation of how these equilibria are constructed. Here is how:

4 Substantive setup

In Japan's parliamentary polity, Sanae Takaichi's ascent illustrates how a new executive can be evaluated by progressively broader audiences during governance rather than simply through an one-short campaign-based nomination. After decades as a legislator and factional

conservative in the LDP, Takaichi first faced the narrowest audience, cabinet colleagues and senior bureaucrats, through her work in key portfolios such as Internal Affairs and Communications, where her policy decisions on telecommunications regulation and administrative reform provided repeated signals about her competence and resolve. These insider assessments were imperfect and often contested; many career bureaucrats and moderate party elders remained skeptical of her hard-line stances even as conservative factions endorsed her. Her 2021 bid for LDP president further broadened evaluative audiences to include party activists and factional actors, revealing deep factional support but also persistent elite ambivalence. Upon becoming Prime Minister in 2025, she shifted the critical audience outward by dissolving the lower house and calling a snap general election in February 2026, effectively inviting the broader Japanese electorate to pass judgment on her governance. Her success in that election, securing a historic super-majority for the LDP, constituted a mass public endorsement that reshaped subsequent elite and bureaucratic evaluations of her capacity to govern. This sequence shows governance as a learning process across audiences of increasing breadth, where early elite signals can be overridden or reframed by observable mass electoral affirmation, and where each audience's response feeds back into the evolving public inference about the politician's performance.

Consider a given parliamentary polity, a new politician has come to power, and her performance is being evaluated by a sequence of audiences. First, this might start off as her cabinet, then government bureaucrats, and eventually the broader public. These audiences hold genuine preferences over governance quality: their endorsements derive from learning about the politician's capacity and performance, as well as from observing one another's assessments. Sometimes the audience publicly opposes the new politician, reporting candidly that they were not satisfied with her performance. Notice that this is not a process of selection via campaigning, but a process of selection while governing.

The politician does not learn her own capacity until arriving at the office after winning the electoral campaign. During her campaign, she outlined plans for how she would strategize once she was in office. Before she enacts any work, she announces this plan to her audience. Everyone knows that even a very capable leader might get unlucky, and her audience might not support her rule. It is also common knowledge that she might enjoy beginner's luck, where she manages to perform well initially despite lacking genuine competence. She knows that her audience may initially agree or disagree, but ultimately, they will reach a consensus on whether to support her rule.

Here is the critical feature: the politician can deploy an institutional toolkit to intervene in the sequence of endorsements. Worried that a few bad episodes will trigger a backlash, she may implement interventions to prevent certain audience members from publicizing

their assessments. To avoid suspicion, she removes audience members from the evaluative sequence without explicitly censoring their opinions. She must remove this audience prior to observing their actual assessment. Substantively, this is the functional equivalent of reassigning officials, restructuring oversight committees, or calling snap elections that reset the information stream.

5 Formal setup

Term this politician the Ruler (R), endowed with executive prerogative and of type good/competent or bad/incompetent. She cares about the public's ultimate verdict of her character, who relies on the prior checks-and-balance of numerous government deputies, whom we call the leaders. Write this as

$$i \in \{\underbrace{L...L}_{n}, F\}$$

For illustration, suppose $n = 1$ and the final verdict from the second citizen determines her payoff. At the start of the game, she commits to a strategy profile:

$$A_R = \{\alpha, \beta\}$$

where α is the probability that she removes the Leader from the evaluative process if she is the good/capable type, and β is the corresponding probability if she is the bad/incapable type.

Upon arriving at the office, Nature reveals her type $\omega \in \{G, B\}$ and she delivers performance for a fixed term. All audience members observe her performance and form private opinions. In other words, they all receive their private signals. Define a binary private signal system such that:

$$\sigma_i \in \{\sigma_G, \sigma_B\}$$

Private signals are informative, and we define the signaling system as follows:

$$Pr(\sigma_G|\omega = G) = Pr(\sigma_B|\omega = B) = p > \frac{1}{2}$$

Both audience members share an initial sense of *confidence* in the electoral system: the pool of candidates is uniformly drawn from politicians with type $\pi_i \in (\underline{\pi}, \bar{\pi})$, entering from a citizen pool such that $\pi_i \in (0, \bar{\pi})$, with the lowest type aware of being incapable but no one certain of being the good type. Denote $\pi = \frac{\underline{\pi}+\bar{\pi}}{2}$ so that citizens believe the politician is the good type with probability $\pi \in (0, 1)$.

Upon receiving their private signal, the Leader chooses between support and protest, and the Follower faces the same choice set such that:

$$A_F = A_L = \{S, P\}$$

The audiences have perfectly aligned preferences and they are genuinely learning instead of strategically communicating for their private gains. All audiences want to support good/competent politicians and protest bad/incompetent ones:

$$U_L(a_L = S|\omega = G) = 1 = U_L(a_L = P|\omega = B); \quad U_L(a_L = S|\omega = B) = 0 = U_L(a_L = P|\omega = G)$$

The Follower faces the same incentive structure ($U_L = U_F$), and the Ruler's payoff depends on the Follower's action:

$$U_R(a_F = S) = 1; \quad U_R(a_F = P) = 0$$

To sum it up, we have a simple binary setup in the classic social learning model: binary actions, binary signals, and a stochastic process. However, the postulation of the stochastic process is now evaluated under a strategic player who is endowed with commitment power that can design an information structure by removing a given number of audiences from publicly demonstrating their received information.

6 One-shot example and its extension: the all-support regime for π^H

6.1 Unbiased prior

Suppose first that $\pi = \frac{1}{2}$ and the Ruler faces two citizens.

Proposition 1. *With an unbiased prior and one leader to demonstrate for the Follower, there is no profitable collusion available.*

When citizens begin with no prior leaning, the Ruler gains nothing from manipulating the information stream. Every signal carries its full weight, and blocking is either detectable or self-defeating. This benchmark establishes that the politics of information management require a pre-existing asymmetry in civic confidence.

6.2 Biased prior: entrenchment through manipulation

Suppose instead the prior is $\pi \in (0, 1)$ and we extend the potential number of leaders that demonstrate for the follower to n, we could obtain a scenario where the citizen under every unique information set will find the Ruler more likely to be good than bad and find it more profitable to support the regime.

Proposition 2. *For any $n \in Q$, as long as $\pi > p$, there exists an optimal information structure α^*, β^* to construct an all-support regime.*

This equilibrium is highly sustainable: it can be supported by any off-path beliefs because it achieves the best possible payoff for both ruler types. Neither Ruler has an incentive to deviate. Under this equilibrium, both Rulers converge to a censorship strategy such that the last citizen always supports the regime. The first citizen's action becomes uninformative, and the blocking game becomes stationary. The result formalizes the intuition behind entrenched one-party states: once civic confidence crosses a threshold, citizens' private doubts are drowned out by the weight of prior endorsements.

6.3 Extension: existence of optimal information structure

So far, we only allowed the Ruler to adapt round by round upon observing the previous audience's move. Suppose instead that the Ruler can commit to a pure strategy profile θ for any fixed number of audience members, so that the strategy space is defined as $\{\boldsymbol{\alpha}^*, \boldsymbol{\beta}^*\}$ where

$$\boldsymbol{\alpha} = \{\alpha_0, \alpha_1, \ldots, \alpha_{n-1}\}$$

designates the strategy profile for the good type, and

$$\boldsymbol{\beta} = \{\beta_0, \beta_1, \ldots, \beta_{n-1}\}$$

designates the strategy profile for the bad type.

Proposition 3. *For any fixed number of audiences in the information stream, there always exists a $\pi \in (0, 1)$ such that an optimal information structure $\{\boldsymbol{\alpha}^*, \boldsymbol{\beta}^*\}$ exists.*

As an interesting generalization of proposition 2, suppose that the Ruler is devising a small circle social experiment. This proposition is saying that with high enough trust, the Ruler can always impose an optimal network structure so that the public will support the policy regardless of the private signal that members netted in the network happen to opt for.

7 Two-shot example and its extension: the regime for π^M where protest bandwagon is always prevented

What happens when civic confidence is not high enough for outright entrenchment? The next result shows that even in this intermediate range, rulers of both types find it profitable to collude—not by explicit coordination, but by converging on the same preemptive strategy.

Lemma 1. *In a one-Leader-two-Followers scenario with an unbiased prior and an unbiased off-path belief, the Leader protests and both Rulers block the second Follower; if the Leader supports, neither Ruler blocks. In other words,* $\alpha_P = \beta_P = 1$ *and* $\alpha_S = \beta_S = 0$.

Because of this profitable maneuver, the expected payoff for not blocking the first agent strictly dominates the expected payoff for blocking. By backward induction, $\alpha_0 = \beta_0 = 0$.

The logic is intuitive. When trust is insufficient to construct an all-support equilibrium, collusion becomes harder to sustain. Citizens are inclined to believe that the good Ruler, being more capable of surviving the natural variance of private signals, is more likely to tolerate protest. Yet as repeated episodes of autocratic governance demonstrate, sophisticated autocrats seldom resort to crude repression and have every incentive to display leniency against public dissent. Ex ante, citizens need not associate any particular blocking behavior with a particular ruler type. As long as one protest appears in the public sequence and the possibility of a protesting bandwagon becomes viable, both Rulers face pressure to enact preemptive blocking strategies. This "collusion" is not explicit coordination but strategic convergence driven by shared incentives.

Does the collusion region extend beyond the knife-edge case? It does.

Lemma 2. *With* $\pi \geq \frac{1}{2}$*, the Leader protests and both Rulers block the second Follower; if the Leader supports, neither Ruler blocks. In other words,* $\alpha_P = \beta_P = 1$ *and* $\alpha_S = \beta_S = 0$.

Even in the three-person setting, there exist profitable ways for both Ruler types to "collaborate." When initial trust is insufficient for entrenchment, a moderately trusting citizenry induces the good Ruler to adopt the blocking regime and collude with the bad Ruler. This is the formal underpinning of the no-protest bandwagon: governance that appears stable and consensual, but whose stability rests on the systematic removal of dissenting voices from the public record.

7.1 Extension to infinite horizon

Adding further followers to the sequence produces a distribution of posteriors virtually identical to the three-person case, because Rulers symmetrically eliminate one signal from the

public stream whenever a protest appears. The intuition: for all sequences where the natural information flow produces a protesting signal, both Rulers find it profitable to intervene and force subsequent citizens to rely on their private signals alone.

Definition 1. *An* additional supporting signal *is a scenario where supporting signals exceed protesting signals in the public sequence; an* additional protesting signal *is defined conversely.*

Proposition 4. *For any $n \in Q$ and $\pi \geq \frac{1}{2}$, with an unbiased off-path belief $\mu(P, S) = \frac{1}{2}$, there exists a collusion scheme in which both Rulers never block after one (additional) supporting signal and always block together after one (additional) protesting signal, so that a protest bandwagon never forms.*

7.2 Substantive discussion

The strategy of removing a chronic sequence of institutional opposition is often coded as autocratic. But it bears a close resemblance to calling snap elections after negative signals from the electorate—precisely the strategy behind the conservative party's snap election after the initial electoral victory of the socialist opponent, and Takaichi's call for a snap election after the centrist Komeito left the partisan coalition. In both cases, the ruling party responded to accumulating negative signals not by tolerating the information flow but by resetting it. The model suggests that this behavior is not pathological but strategically rational for any ruler—good or bad—operating in the intermediate trust regime.

7.3 Robustness: inaction types

One might worry that the collusion result depends on citizens correctly distinguishing between a blocked signal and an absent one. Suppose the Leader has ϵ probability of being a commitment type that refrains from political action regardless of private signal, observationally equivalent to being blocked from the Follower's perspective.

Proposition 5. *The presence of the inaction type does not meaningfully alter the main result.*

If anything, the presence of apathetic citizens *expands* the collusion-feasible region: more inaction types make blocking less conspicuous, giving both Ruler types additional cover.

8 Empirical evidence: Cross-national pattern of public trust and turnover

What is the general relationship between the frequency of executive turnover and political confidence in government? Political behaviorists have documented that citizens foster confidence when exposed to complete alternations in power (Otjes 2025), winner's restraint (Werner et al. 2025), or institutional forbearance (Ingham 2023), but these effects are contingent on a sequencing of democratic erosion episodes that does not always obtain in practice (Yeung 2025).

The causal arrow, however, also runs in the opposite direction. Elite strategies are endogenous to the level of confidence citizens are willing to invest. Elites are enabled by their delegated toolkit through the confidence of their citizens, especially when the effective scope of institutional constraint remains questionable (Achen and Bartels 2017; Bartels 2023). How does government respond to inflated or deflated political trust?

Two stylized facts demand a unified account. First, a population can become locked in a cycle of mistrust even when citizens would welcome government intervention (Aghion et al. 2010), generating a "society of fear, poverty, and disorder" (Fearon and Laitin 1996) in which even competent rulers cannot govern effectively. Second, a population can become locked into complacent entrenchment, where citizens actively support regimes characterized by indefinite states of exception, as in Nayib Bukele's El Salvador (Hale 2025), while elites pander to prevailing sentiment without diligence in public service.

Neither outcome is desirable. The question is what determines which equilibrium a polity falls into, and how that equilibrium relates to civic confidence.

To get at this question empirically, I merge data from the World Values Survey and the Varieties of Democracy project. Political confidence comes from the WVS item on trust in government, which I split into terciles (low, medium, high) at the 33rd and 66th percentiles of the sample distribution. Executive turnover comes from V-Dem: for presidential systems I use the head-of-state turnover indicator (`v2elturnhos`), for parliamentary systems the head-of-government indicator (`v2elturnhog`), each coded on a three-point scale (0 = no turnover, 1 = moderate, 2 = high). The sample excludes closed autocracies—where neither trust nor turnover is meaningfully measured—and retains electoral autocracies, electoral democracies, and liberal democracies as classified by V-Dem's regimes-of-the-world index (`v2x_regime`). I also exclude Bangladesh in 1996 and Pakistan throughout, both of which are clear outliers driven by regime-specific disruptions unrelated to the trust-turnover mechanism.

The pattern is puzzling. Figure 1 sorts polities into the three confidence terciles and asks: how much turnover does each group experience? Among high-confidence polities, the

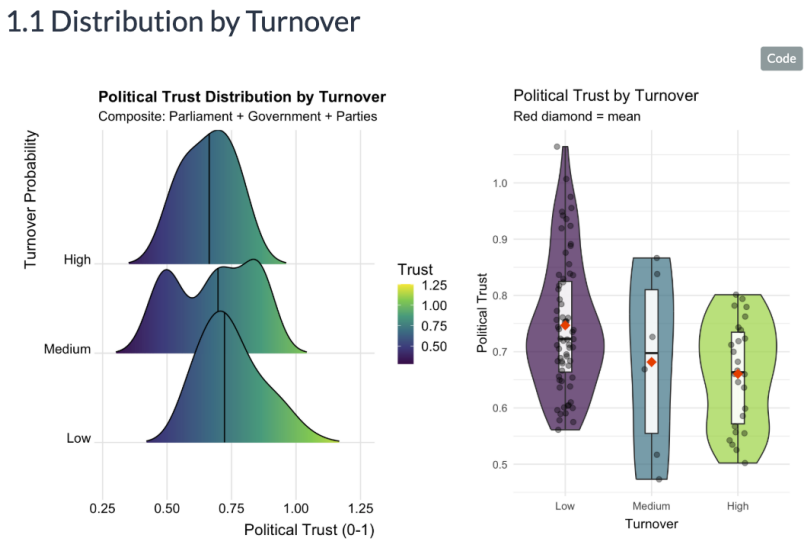

Figure 1. Distribution of executive turnover within each political confidence tercile. Each panel displays the proportion of polities experiencing low, medium, and high turnover at a given trust level. Among high-confidence polities, the distribution is compressed at the low-turnover end; among low-confidence polities, turnover is dispersed across all three categories with no dominant mode.

answer is almost uniformly "very little." The distribution is compressed at the low end—these are countries where leaders stay in power, and citizens report trusting them. Among low-confidence polities, by contrast, turnover is spread across the full range. Some low-trust countries churn through leaders; others do not. While the high-trust cluster converges, the low-trust cluster diffuses.

This could be because high-trust polities are somehow more satisfied with their rulers, but it could also be that confidence itself enables the kind of information management that suppresses turnover. When citizens grant enough baseline trust, the ruler can afford to remove negative signals before they accumulate into a bandwagon. Sustaining low turnover, in turn, requires a certain threshold of confidence, below which even favorable private signals cannot prevent a protest cascade.

Reading the relationship in the other direction (Figure 2) sharpens the asymmetry. Among polities with frequent turnovers, confidence levels are all over the map—some citizens remain trusting despite instability, others do not. But among polities with low turnover, confidence is reliably high. The asymmetry is suggestive: confidence is *necessary but not sufficient* for low turnover, while turnover can occur at any level of trust. This is precisely the pattern the model predicts. The entrenchment regime ($\pi > p$) locks in low turnover with high confidence. The low-trust regime ($\pi < \frac{1}{2}$) generates turnover regardless of ruler qual-

Part 2: By System Type

2.1 Faceted Violin Plot

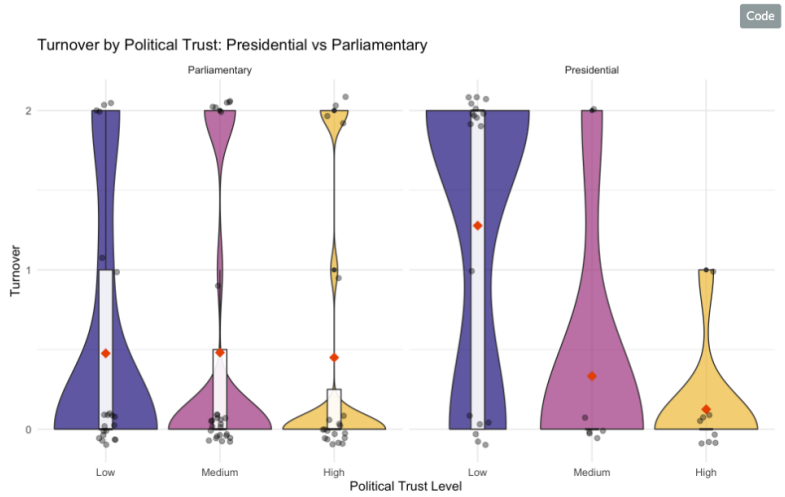

Figure 2. Distribution of political confidence within each turnover category, faceted by system type. Among low-turnover polities, confidence is reliably high regardless of whether the system is presidential or parliamentary. Among high-turnover polities, confidence varies widely. The trust-turnover nexus is substantially more homogeneous in parliamentary systems, where the head of government serves at the pleasure of the legislature.

ity. The intermediate regime—the no-protest bandwagon—is where the interesting politics happen, and where the king's gambit becomes feasible.

The pattern holds across regime subtypes. Disaggregating by V-Dem's regime classification, the trust-turnover gradient is visible in electoral autocracies, stronger in electoral democracies, and strongest in liberal democracies—consistent with the model's prediction that better institutional infrastructure makes the trust-turnover nexus more operative. A Kruskal-Wallis test confirms that turnover distributions differ significantly across trust terciles in the democratic subsample. Moreover, the relationship is substantially more homogeneous in parliamentary systems. In presidential systems, the link between confidence and turnover is noisier, perhaps because term limits and the separation of powers introduce institutional constraints that partially decouple elite survival from public sentiment. In parliamentary systems, where the head of government serves at the pleasure of a legislative majority, the trust-turnover nexus is more direct—and more amenable to the kind of information management the model describes.

9 Democratization as an equilibrium selection device

It is straightforward to postulate that the ex ante payoff for a given politician will increase as public trust increases.

9.1 Micro-founding trust: the cost of entrance and the party ladder

The preceding analysis takes civic confidence π as given. But where does it come from? To close the model, I micro-founded the politician pool by requiring that politicians should find it beneficial or not dominated to enter into political campaigns, which means that the lowest type entering the political arena is just indifferent between entering and opting out. Suppose further that only party-nominated politicians can enter the pool for competition and party imposes some private cost against a potential politician. Citizens do not observe the direct cost of selection imposed by the internal party machine but inherit the prior shaped by the record of the politician last installed by that party. In other words, party reputation is sticky. Neither the party nor the citizen observes a politician's type directly; the party must impose costs to screen out lower types.

9.1.1 Democratize by concession or confidence

Suppose first that $\pi < \frac{1}{2}$. Because the original cutoff was $\underline{\pi}$, the baseline cost of entering c_0 is:

$$c_0 = \frac{\underline{\pi}p^2 + (1-\underline{\pi})(1-p)^2}{(\bar{\pi}-\underline{\pi})(1+2p^2-2p)}$$

because a type $\pi_i = \pi_i'$ has expected payoff if selected:

$$EU_i = \pi_i' \cdot V_G + (1-\pi_i') \cdot V_B = p(2\pi - 1) + 1 - \pi \quad \text{where} \quad V_G = \frac{p^2}{1+2p^2-2p}; \quad V_B = \frac{(1-p)^2}{1+2p^2-2p}$$

Suppose $\pi \in [\frac{1}{2}, p)$. The baseline entry cost is:

$$c_0 = \frac{1}{\bar{\pi}-\underline{\pi}} \cdot \frac{\underline{\pi}p + (1-\underline{\pi})(1-p)}{1+p^2-p}$$

because a type $\pi_i = \pi_i'$ has expected payoff:

$$EU_i = \pi_i' \cdot V_G + (1-\pi_i') \cdot V_B = \frac{p(2\pi-1)+1-\pi}{1+p^2-p} \quad \text{where} \quad V_G = \frac{p}{1+p^2-p}; \quad V_B = \frac{1-p}{1+p^2-p}$$

Finally, suppose $\pi > p$. Once a politician enters, she achieves uniform support and receives payoff 1. The entering decision is no longer sensitive to type: if the highest type is motivated to enter, so is the lowest. This scenario is never a stable equilibrium because it requires $\bar{\pi} > 2p > 1$. The screening mechanism, in other words, breaks down precisely when it is no longer needed—entrenchment makes quality irrelevant.

The party receives a non-trivial payoff when its nominee receives public support and is punished (payoff 0) when its nominee is protested by the Follower. For a benchmark, suppose there are two Leaders and one Follower.

There are two potential equilibria to be constructed here: one is when initial trust is low and the Ruler must democratize to enable some benevolent intervention. This happens when $\pi_I > \frac{1}{2}$ and $\pi_O < \frac{1}{2}$.

We want to construct one equilibrium where $\pi_I > p$ and $\pi_O < p$, and it is compatible with the fact that they are competing with one another in the election, such that the chance of a party i winning party j is given by a contest success function $\frac{\pi_i}{\pi_i+\pi_j}$. Given a uniform upper limit $\bar{\pi}$, we must thus have

$$\underline{\pi}_I > 2p - \bar{\pi} \quad \underline{\pi}_O < 2p - \bar{\pi}$$

The task to construct the equilibrium is to find *a* c such that

$$\frac{\frac{\underline{\pi}_I + \bar{\pi}}{2}}{\frac{\underline{\pi}_I + \underline{\pi}_O}{2} + \bar{\pi}} \cdot 1 = c + c_0$$

$$\frac{\frac{\underline{\pi}_O + \bar{\pi}}{2}}{\frac{\underline{\pi}_I + \underline{\pi}_O}{2} + \bar{\pi}} \cdot 1 = c$$

With some algebra, this is feasible if and only if $c < \frac{1}{1+2\bar{\pi}}$. This condition is feasible only with a peculiar combination of parameter space such that

$$(1 + 2\bar{\pi})\Big[(1 - p) + (2\pi - \bar{\pi})(2p - 1)\Big] < 2(\bar{\pi} - \pi)\,(1 + p^2 - p) \tag{1}$$

Suppose the party is more discerning than a random machine, such that they would correctly bet on the highest type, we could have

$$\bar{\pi} < \frac{1 - p}{2p - 1}$$

This condition is more stringent if p is larger, so very perversely, a more informed polity is undermining the prospect of democratization.

The proposition captures the "king's gambit": by subsidizing a credible opposition through costly elections, the incumbent party raises the perceived quality of the entire political pool above the entrenchment threshold. The opposition gains reputation not through its own track record but through the screening effect of the election cost. Citizens, observing that only high types would pay $c + c_0$ to enter, rationally update their confidence in the system as a whole. The result is that competitive elections, paradoxically, can lock in one-party dominance.

Proposition 6. *There always exists a king's gambit if* $(1+2\bar{\pi})\Big[(1-p)+(2\pi-\bar{\pi})(2p-1)\Big] < 2(\bar{\pi} - \pi)\,(1 + p^2 - p)$ *when* $\pi \in (\frac{1}{2}, p)$ *and* $\bar{\pi} > p$. *This room shrinks as the precision of information in nature increases.*

The substantive intuition is captured as follows: the legacy of the existing record of ruling over the polity, regardless of how bleak it used to be, serves the incumbent party to some extent. This helps the incumbent to make the gambit because it feeds an advantage to overcome the challenge from an opponent who comes from an inferior electoral prospect. Entrenchment is achieved when the existing party relies on viable facts that they could use

to pit against an electorally more competitive opponent, relenting some genuine risk of losing the office. Lack of commitment power at entrenchment was unlocked precisely by a genuinely competitive election.

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9.2 Proof of Proposition 1

Proof. Term the strategy profile as $\alpha, \beta \in [0, 1]$ for the good Ruler and the bad Ruler. Within this two-person game, there are six entries in the distribution of potential posteriors:

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mu(\text{Support}, \sigma_g) &= \frac{p^2(1-\alpha)}{p^2(1-\alpha) + (1-p)^2(1-\beta)} \\
\mu(\text{Support}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{p(1-p)(1-\alpha)}{p(1-p)(1-\alpha) + (1-p)p(1-\beta)} = \mu(\text{Protest}, \sigma_g) \\
\mu(\text{Protest}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{(1-p)^2(1-\alpha)}{(1-\alpha)(1-p)^2 + (1-\beta)p^2} \\
\mu(\text{Block}, \sigma_g) &= \frac{\alpha p}{\alpha p + \beta(1-p)} \\
\mu(\text{Block}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{(1-p)\alpha}{(1-p)\alpha + \beta p}
\end{aligned}
$$

Term the corresponding action profile as $A_\mu = \{a_{Pg}, a_{Pb}, a_{Ng}, a_{Nb}, a_{\emptyset g}, a_{\emptyset b}\}$; $a_\mu \in \{0, 1\}$ for all $a_\mu \in A_\mu$, where $a_\mu = 1$ denotes support and $a_\mu = 0$ denotes protest. □

9.3 Proof of Proposition 2

Proof. Rewrite the posterior system with prior π:

$$
\begin{aligned}
\mu(\text{Support}, \sigma_g) &= \frac{\pi\, p^2(1-\alpha)}{\pi\, p^2(1-\alpha) + (1-\pi)(1-p)^2(1-\beta)} \\
\mu(\text{Support}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{\pi\, p(1-p)(1-\alpha)}{\pi\, p(1-p)(1-\alpha) + (1-\pi)\, p(1-p)(1-\beta)} = \mu(\text{Protest}, \sigma_g) \\
\mu(\text{Protest}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{\pi\, (1-p)^2(1-\alpha)}{\pi\, (1-p)^2(1-\alpha) + (1-\pi)\, p^2(1-\beta)} \\
\mu(\text{Block}, \sigma_g) &= \frac{\pi\, \alpha p}{\pi\, \alpha p + (1-\pi)\, \beta(1-p)} \\
\mu(\text{Block}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{\pi\, \alpha(1-p)}{\pi\, \alpha(1-p) + (1-\pi)\, \beta p}
\end{aligned}
$$

The most profitable equilibrium ($A_\mu = \{1, 1, 1, 1, 1, 1\}$) requires:

$$
\mu(\text{Protest}, \sigma_b) > \frac{1}{2} \quad \text{and} \quad \mu(\text{Block}, \sigma_b) > \frac{1}{2}
$$

The entailed constraints on α are:

$$
\alpha > \frac{1-\pi}{\pi}\, \beta\, \frac{p}{1-p} \quad \text{and} \quad \alpha < 1 - \frac{1-\pi}{\pi} \cdot \frac{p^2(1-\beta)}{(1-p)^2}
$$

This region exists if and only if:

$$\frac{1-\pi}{\pi}\beta\frac{p}{1-p} < 1 - \frac{1-\pi}{\pi}\cdot\frac{p^2(1-\beta)}{(1-p)^2}$$

which requires $\beta > \frac{(1-p)^2\frac{\pi}{1-\pi}-p^2}{p(1-2p)}$. This is smaller than 1 if and only if $\pi > p > \frac{1}{2}$. □

9.4 Proof of Proposition 3

It is equivalent for the Ruler to block a fixed number of public signals before the Follower. The Follower can have $2(2^n-1)$ potential information sets. Focusing on the worst cases, for any n we need:

$$\pi(1-p)^n\cdot\alpha_0 > (1-\pi)p^n\cdot\beta_0$$

and

$$\pi\alpha_n\cdot(1-p) > (1-\pi)\beta_n\cdot p$$

Together: $\frac{\pi}{1-\pi} > \max\left\{\frac{p^n\cdot\beta_0}{(1-p)^n\cdot\alpha_n}, \frac{\beta_n\cdot p}{(1-p)\alpha_n}\right\}$. Since $\lim_{\pi\to 1}\frac{\pi}{1-\pi} = \infty$, there always exists a π satisfying this condition.

9.5 Proof of Lemma 1

Suppose first the Leader protests. The third citizen's posteriors are:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mu(\text{Protest, Support}, \sigma_g) &= \frac{p^2(1-\alpha_P)}{p^2(1-\alpha_P)+(1-p)^2(1-\beta_P)} \\
\mu(\text{Protest, Support}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{p(1-p)^2(1-\alpha_P)}{p(1-p)^2(1-\alpha_P)+(1-p)p^2(1-\beta_P)} = \mu(\text{Protest, Protest}, \sigma_g) \\
\mu(\text{Protest, Protest}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{(1-p)^3(1-\alpha_P)}{(1-\alpha_P)(1-p)^3+(1-\beta_P)p^3} \\
\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_g) &= \frac{\alpha_P p(1-p)}{\alpha_P p(1-p)+\beta_P p(1-p)} \\
\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_b) &= \frac{(1-p)^2\alpha_P}{(1-p)^2\alpha_P+\beta_P p^2}
\end{aligned}$$

The stability requirement demands $\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_g) \geq \frac{1}{2}$ and $\mu(\text{Protest, Protest}, \sigma_g) \geq \frac{1}{2}$, which under $p > \frac{1}{2}$ requires $\alpha_P = \beta_P = 1$. This is profitable for both Rulers: blocking yields p (good) and $1-p$ (bad), versus $p^2 < p$ and $(1-p)^2 < 1-p$ without blocking.

9.6 Proof of Lemma 2

Rewriting with prior π:

$$\mu(\text{Protest, Support}, \sigma_g) = \frac{\pi p^2(1-\alpha_P)}{\pi p^2(1-\alpha_P) + (1-\pi)(1-p)^2(1-\beta_P)}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Support}, \sigma_b) = \frac{\pi p(1-p)^2(1-\alpha_P)}{\pi p(1-p)^2(1-\alpha_P) + (1-\pi)(1-p)p^2(1-\beta_P)} = \mu(\text{Protest, Protest}, \sigma_g)$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Protest}, \sigma_b) = \frac{\pi(1-p)^3(1-\alpha_P)}{\pi(1-\alpha_P)(1-p)^3 + (1-\pi)(1-\beta_P)p^3}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_g) = \frac{\pi\alpha_P p(1-p)}{\pi\alpha_P p(1-p) + (1-\pi)\beta_P p(1-p)}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_b) = \frac{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_P}{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_P + (1-\pi)\beta_P p^2}$$

Requiring $\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_g) \geq \frac{1}{2}$ and $\mu(\text{Protest, Protest}, \sigma_g) \geq \frac{1}{2}$ yields:

$$\pi\alpha_P \geq (1-\pi)\beta_P \tag{1}$$
$$\pi(1-p)(1-\alpha_P) \geq (1-\pi)p(1-\beta_P) \tag{2}$$

giving $\alpha_P \in \left[\frac{1-\pi}{\pi}\beta_P,\ 1 - \frac{(1-\pi)p}{(1-p)\pi}(1-\beta_P)\right]$. This is feasible if and only if $\beta_P \geq \frac{\pi-p}{(1-\pi)(1-2p)}$, which given $\beta_P \leq 1$ requires $\pi \geq \frac{1}{2}$.

9.7 Proof of Proposition 4

$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block, Support}, \sigma_g) = \frac{\pi\alpha_{D\emptyset}p(1-p)}{\pi\alpha_{D\emptyset}p(1-p) + (1-\pi)\beta_{D\emptyset}p(1-p)}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block, Support}, \sigma_b) = \frac{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_{D\emptyset}}{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_{D\emptyset} + (1-\pi)\beta_{D\emptyset}p^2}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block, Protest}, \sigma_g) = \frac{\pi\alpha_{D\emptyset}p(1-p)}{\pi\alpha_{D\emptyset}p(1-p) + (1-\pi)\beta_{D\emptyset}p(1-p)}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block, Protest}, \sigma_b) = \frac{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_{D\emptyset}}{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_{D\emptyset} + (1-\pi)\beta_{D\emptyset}p^2}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block, Block}, \sigma_g) = \frac{\pi\alpha_{D\emptyset}p(1-p)}{\pi\alpha_{D\emptyset}p(1-p) + (1-\pi)\beta_{D\emptyset}p(1-p)}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block, Block}, \sigma_b) = \frac{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_{D\emptyset}}{\pi(1-p)^2\alpha_{D\emptyset} + (1-\pi)\beta_{D\emptyset}p^2}$$

The incentive structure is virtually identical to the three-person case. As long as the off-path belief does not associate blocking with a particular Ruler type, Rulers can credibly

commit to blocking indefinitely. The cases where an initial supporting signal is overturned by consecutive protests are structurally equivalent to having an equal number of protesting and supporting signals, which falls under the same blocking incentive.

9.8 Proof of Proposition 5

With inaction probability ϵ, the posteriors become:

$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_g) = \frac{\pi(\alpha_P + \epsilon)p(1-p)}{\pi(\alpha_P + \epsilon)p(1-p) + (1-\pi)(\beta_P + \epsilon)p(1-p)}$$
$$\mu(\text{Protest, Block}, \sigma_b) = \frac{\pi(1-p)^2(\alpha_P + \epsilon)}{\pi(1-p)^2(\alpha_P + \epsilon) + (1-\pi)(\beta_P + \epsilon)p^2}$$

The constraints $\pi(\alpha_P + \epsilon) \geq (1-\pi)(\beta_P + \epsilon)$ and $\pi(1-p)(1-\alpha_P) \geq (1-\pi)p(1-\beta_P)$ yield:

$$\frac{1-\pi}{\pi}(\beta_P + \epsilon) - \epsilon \leq \alpha_P \leq 1 - \frac{1-\pi}{\pi}\frac{p}{1-p}(1-\beta_P)$$

which is feasible when $\pi \leq \pi^{***} = \frac{1+\epsilon}{2+\epsilon} > \frac{1}{2}$. Since $\frac{\partial \pi^{***}}{\partial \epsilon} > 0$, more inactive types expand the collusion-feasible region, analogous to better information quality.

For the all-support threshold, the modified posteriors with ϵ yield the same constraint $\pi > p$ for entrenchment, confirming that the inaction type does not alter the fundamental structure of the result.